

Changes to Policy and Regulations

School of Social & Environmental Sustainability, May 2026

What the QAA Found

The problems

Inconsistent degree calculation spreadsheets across the University

No institutional training on the Code of Assessment

Regulations “long, dense and complex”

Inconsistent extension and EC processes

No oversight of local handbooks

The instructions

Regulation simplification

New Award of Credit rules

New Extenuating Circumstances Policy

New approaches to managing risk, ensuring student welfare, and quality assurance

New approaches to standardised, compassionate communications

The core direction

A shift to greater, and sometimes total, standardisation, where University practice has drifted out of line with sector norms.

A shift to greater accountability, assurance and institutional-level oversight

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The University has submitted and agreed a public Action Plan with QAA.

Our Tertiary Quality Enhancement Review has been brought forward to 2027-28: here the university must be able to **demonstrate clear evidence of addressing all the issues**.

The consequences of failing to do so are severe.

The Deadline

QAA TPR at 22:

…prioritis[e] completion of the regulation simplification programme to enable implementation of an appropriate system for programme-level aggregation by academic year 2027-28

QAA TPR at 76:

The developments currently planned (reforms to award of credit, progression rules harmonisation) “are not sufficient to fully mitigate against the risk that erroneous outcomes might occur”

Simplified regulations live: August 2026

The QAA has mandated a university-wide programme-level aggregation system by 2027–28. That system has to be built in 2026–27, and it needs to know what rules it is implementing. Simplified regulations therefore need to be live by **this August**.

Two Regulation Changes

Award of Credit

Moving the University from a very unusual system (the “75% rule”, unique in the sector) to a sector-standard way of awarding credit – the process of saying “this course should count towards a degree” or not.

New Degree Regulations

All 83 sets of our taught degree regulations are being replaced by 3 sets of much simpler and clearer regulations – primarily rewriting and clarifying, not making many underlying changes (but there are some!).

Award of Credit Reforms

Three interdependent elements:

Credit based on achievement

Credit awarded for courses with a satisfactory grade (D3 or above)

Degree awards are based only on course grades and not programme-wide calculations

Compensatory credit at session level

Students who do not pass all courses in a session but have ≥ D3 in two-thirds or more of that session's credits have shown engagement and are awarded credit for all courses in the session

Clear, automatic support for students with EC or small volumes of unremedied work

Honours rules aligned with all other levels

Limited reassessment introduced at Honours where not already present, as already exists at every other level

Resit grades fully capped at C3/D3; only first-diet grades count for classification

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1. This only changes the award of credit ("should the grades count towards a degree award?") and *does not* affect either the grades awarded or the GPA thresholds for award of a degree.

2. These elements work together. Credit based on achievement requires a route to remedy failure; that route requires a compensation mechanism for circumstances where remedy is not possible.

AoC: Summary of Changes

What changes

How we count credit: course-by-course and session-level and with session GPAs, not programme-wide percentages or calculations

All “75% rules” are removed

Honours comes into line with all other levels (including rules on reassessment)

Reassessment grades capped at D3/C3 (currently only grade points are capped)

What does not change

Classification thresholds and GPA requirements for awards

The grades required for degree classification

Any course/degree requirements which change the award of credit (e.g. PSRB requirements in Medicine, Veterinary Medicine, Engineering, Education, Nursing, etc.)

Only first-diet grades used for classification

Remember that a student can still graduate with a failed course on their transcript – as they can now. The failed grade counts in their GPA, just as it does now. We are not lowering the bar for degree awards: we are simplifying how we calculate the volume of work that goes into a degree calculation.

Reassessment Changes

What's new: Limited reassessment at Honours (where it didn't previously exist). This brings Honours into line with every other level of study. Resit grades fully capped at D3 (UG) and C3 (PGT) – grades *and* grade points.

What's the same: Only first-diet grades count for classification. A resit can lift a student over a progression or award-of-degree threshold, but cannot lift them into a higher classification.

What's changed: *Only* students who need reassessment for PSRB requirements or to hit a progression GPA or to graduate are given reassessment opportunities. (Not everyone who failed a course.) Students who already have enough credit through compensation do not sit again. Far fewer resits for staff and students – even with Honours reassessment options added in.

Award of Credit Scenarios

A3

B2

C1

C1

C3

C3

Scenario 1:

UG or PGT student with 6x 20 credit courses, course grades to the left.

Credit: All courses ≥ D3, so all receive credit. Session has 120 credits awarded.

Further assessment: Credit awarded and all course grades above the reassessment threshold; no further assessment.

GPA: Session GPA = 14.7

Award of Credit Scenarios

A3

B2

C1

C1

C3

F1

Scenario 2:

UG or PGT student with 6x 20 credit courses, course grades to the left.

Credit: Not all courses ≥ D3, so move to compensatory credit. More than two thirds of session (≥ 80 credits) of courses are at D3 for session, so full session awarded compensatory credit. Session has 120 credits awarded.

Further assessment: Credit awarded and the student meets the progression GPA threshold; no further assessment.

GPA: Session GPA = 13.5

Award of Credit Scenarios

C2

C2

C3

C3

~~D3~~ C3

~~D3~~ C3

Scenario 3:

PGT student with 6x 20 credit courses, course grades to the left.

Credit: All courses ≥ D3, so all receive credit. Session has 120 credits awarded.

Further assessment: Credit awarded *but* two courses below the PGT reassessment threshold meaning the progression/award GPA will be lower than required; Academic Review Panel (what was a progression board) may permit reassessment in order to improve the GPA *for progression and award of degree only.*

GPA: Session GPA = 11.3

After reassessment: Credit already awarded, not revisited. Student improves grades. Grades *and* grade points are capped at C3 for PGTs.

GPA: First diet session GPA = 11.3 (for Merit/Distinction), 12.3 at reassessment (for progression and award of degree)

Award of Credit Scenarios

B3

B3

C2

C2

EC

EC

Scenario 4:

UG student with 6x 20 credit courses, course grades to the left.

Credit: Not all courses ≥ D3, so move to compensatory credit. More than two thirds of session (≥ 80 credits) of courses are at D3 for session, so full session awarded compensatory credit/ Session has 120 credits awarded.

Further assessment: Credit awarded, but policy has always been that students should always get the opportunity to demonstrate their learning, so if any further assessment is available the EC courses should be assessed as first attempts at the second diet. *Exceptionally,* in the final year of an Honours or Integrated Masters degree, a final session GPA may be calculated after the spring diet over the four courses to allow summer graduation.

GPA: If no reassessment available, session GPA = 14.0

Award of Credit Benefits

One set of Code of Assessment credit rules across all levels: far easier to remember, easier to advise students, easier to move between mindset of Honours and pre-Honours and Masters

No more programme-wide percentage calculations of submission figures per student across years of assessment; vastly simpler calculations and easier to check

Net reduction in marking workload (even with Honours reassessment): reassessment eligibility is limited only to students who need reassessment to hit a progression GPA or to graduate, and the first-diet rule, compensatory credit, and capped reassessment grades remove pressure for unnecessary resits (e.g. at Masters level)

Maintains high academic standards: **credit now requires achievement**

New Degree Regulations

UG

Replaces 34 individual regulation files. Covers standard undergraduate degrees, integrated masters, professional education, intercalated degrees, and certificates and diplomas.

- 13 require no programme-specific changes at all
- 10 affected only by generic simplifications
- 12 have programme-specific requirements, included in the regulations

UG-Clin

Replaces 6 regulation files for medical, veterinary, dental, and nursing programmes.

All substantive provisions from every programme have been preserved.

PGT

Replaces 43 regulation files. The existing landscape contained an enormous volume of duplication.

- 13 require no programme-specific
- 33 of 43 fully compatible with consolidated regulations
- 10 have programme-specific requirements, included in the regulations

PGR

Replaces 26 regulation files. No changes but a lot of consolidation of existing text.

DR: Style

15.4 The College and School will provide all candidates with written information on the specific level of performance required to obtain entry to each Honours and Integrated Masters degree programme in the School. This information will be made available to candidates at the start of the session preceding that in which Honours study normally commences.

15.3 Exceptionally, a candidate who does not meet all of the requirements in either §15.1 or §15.2 may be offered admission to Honours, or to an Integrated Masters programme, if the Head of School (or their nominee) judges that in other respects the candidate's previous performance offers a reasonable prospect of the candidate reaching the minimum standard required for the award to which admission is granted. A candidate so admitted must remedy any credit shortfall in relation to §15.1 or §15.2 in order to achieve the relevant credit total, as stated in §16.1 or §17.1, required for the degree.

9. Some programmes may have additional or higher entry requirements to Honours. These will be published by the relevant School in the academic session before you intend to enter Honours.

If you do not make the requirements for entry to Honours, you may still be admitted at the discretion of the Head of School or their nominee if your performance suggests that you can succeed. This may mean you need to fulfil any remaining requirements for entry during your Honours years.

DR: Text

96%

Fewer Files

109 files → 4 files

89%

Reduction in Text

185,320 words → ~19,800 words

DR: SES/CoSS UG

For undergraduate degrees the new consolidated regulations preserve almost all existing provisions. The main changes are structural:

- Progression standardised (9.0 for UG)
- Removing otiose requirements like credit-count progress thresholds
- Some programme-specific detail (including what used to be called Qualifying Courses) moves from generic regulations to programme specifications, which Boards of Study control directly
- Progress Committees renamed Academic Review Panels (same function)

One substantive change: Honours classification weightings are being rationalised across the university to two permitted options (50:50 and 25:75).

DR: SES/CoSS PGT and PGR

For PGT (College of Social Sciences): the consolidation from 43 separate regulation files to one unified document preserves all CoSS provisions. Agreed standardisations affect all Colleges equally:

- Progression standardised (12.0 for PGT)
- Credit-passed thresholds simplified to GPA-only approach
- Merit and Distinction criteria moved to the Code of Assessment (thresholds unchanged; location changed)

No outstanding questions have been identified for CoSS at PGT or PGR level. No programme-specific changes are required beyond the standardisations above.

Which Regulations Apply?

The **Code of Assessment**, which includes the rules on award of credit, applies to all students afresh in every new academic session. **Degree Regulations** apply to students on entry to their degree, and reset on entry to Honours or the Integrated Masters.

Entered degree/Honours/Integrated Masters

2025-26 or earlier

Award of Credit
New Code of Assessment & Award of Credit regulations apply from 2026-27 onwards

Transition
Previous years' session GPAs calculated under old regulations and frozen. Degree award guarantee applies: if a student does not get a degree under the new AoC regs but would have under the old ones, the student will be awarded their degree

Degree Regulations
Existing degree regulations apply in full

Entered degree/Hons/IntegM

2026-27 or later

Award of Credit
New Code of Assessment & Award of Credit regulations apply in full

Degree Regulations
New degree regulations apply in full

What will Change for Boards?

Right now

Primary responsibility and burden: local administrators, AOs, and Chairs of Boards.

Multiple spreadsheet formats, often maintained locally

Manual cross-checking of programme-wide percentages

Complex Honours special-regulation calculations

Extensive scrutiny of edge cases that the 75% rule creates

Inconsistent templates across programmes

From 2026-27

Responsibility shifting to the centre for calculation templates: local administrators, AOs, and Chairs of Boards have to work with much simpler regulations.

Standardised board pack templates

Session-level credit and GPA

No programme-wide percentage calculations

Clearer scrutiny focused on genuine edge cases

Consistent University-provided templates and student communications

From 2027-28

Responsibility primarily shifted to the centre.

Automated programme-level aggregation system

Board packs generated centrally

Significantly reduced manual calculation burden

Boards of Examiners should be involved in academic questions as a ‘wash-up’ of the semester or session

Regulations Timeline

- Regulations and policies: finalised and published from May onwards
- Student communications (in partnership with students): **from July 2026**
- Simplified regulations: live from August 2026
- Exam boards under new AoC regulations: exit awards January 2027, main boards May 2027
- Automated degree calculation system: 2027-28
- Tertiary Quality Enhancement Review: 2027-28

Beyond Regulations: Clarity, Consistency, Assurance

It is necessary that our rules and information must be **clear**, must be **known**, must **live in one place**, and must **flow reliably**:

- **Cyclical, tracked training** on the Code of Assessment and for AOs/Chairs
- Standardised and audited Board of Examiners **processes and procedures**
- **Extenuating Circumstances continuous improvement:** automated extension requests/DAPs, reporting dashboards, Stage 2 standardisation and automation
- Revisions to **APG/policy site** and **Instructions for Boards of Examiners**
- **Standardised communications and templates** for student outcomes
- **Programme Specification** harmonisation
- **Degree calculation tool:** development of a central system by 2027-28

Beyond Regs: Moodle/Handbooks

New **governance and standardisation of student-facing local content** (student 'handbooks'): All student-facing content must not be repeated or glossed, and now has sign-off requirements and lives in one of four tiers:

- *Institutional:* written centrally, owned by Registry/ASG
- *College:* specific to College-level arrangements
- *School:* School-level practices and procedures
- *Programme or course:* the local material you actually own

Standardisation of Moodle use

- one course code = one Moodle course
- all assessment outcomes stored in Gradebook, no MyGrades opt-outs
- standardised naming conventions for assessments, etc.

Beyond Regs: Moodle/Handbooks

What this means for workload:

- You stop rewriting University content that’s already written centrally
- Central content are links that update every year
- You stop having to update material with every change and worrying about missing any changes
- You own the programme and course material that only you can write – everything else comes from the University or a system like the Course Catalogue

Overall

In summary, the following are being **removed** or **reduced**:

- Boards of Examiners under simplified regulations will be significantly simpler, with standardised templates and, from 2027-28, automated aggregation
- Manual degree calculation spreadsheets will be replaced by a central system
- Schools will not need to constantly maintain rewritten University content in handbooks (central content will be delivered as links, with named sign-off for Schools/Colleges)
- Routine EC processing will be increasingly automated

Process and system standardisation also means increased central training resources and defined escalation/information routes

Overall

What requires action:

- Reviews of course/programme specifications (light touch, coordinated with degree expert groups from April, looking at automation)
- Moodle course structures aligned to one-code-one-course by start of 2026-27
- Assessment-level metadata captured (in Gradebook) as part of course setup
- Staff completing Code of Assessment training, Chairs/AOs attending training
- Handbook transition: identifying local content, removing legacy material
- Learning new regulations, new places to find things

What This Means

This will involve a lot of updating of our knowledge, changing what we do (for the better), and simplifying what we do.

None of us designed the totality of the system we are now fixing; its existence is not our fault. But it **is** our system and it affects out student outcomes and every part of our students' time at this university, and we are collectively not at liberty to permit it to continue as it is.

With so much change taking place, we can't expect everyone to know everything – it is okay to **not presume knowledge** and to ask questions and double-check policy and processes. A team will be available for queries. Encourage people to remember we're all in the same situation!

Summer 2026 Roadmap

Phase 1: Data returns

May – June

PRODUCE

Course list review	**ongoing**
Moodle tracker contacts	**27 May**
Course withdrawals	**22 Jun**
BoE minutes	**26 Jun**

ANSWER

Spec / plan contacts	**as requested**
Flag plan changes	**ongoing**

TEST

MyGrades UAT	**June**

Phase 2: Standardisation

July – August

PRODUCE

Moodle standardisation	**31 Jul**
DAP eligibility flagging	**with Moodle**
Handbook updates	**14 Aug**
Remove local content	**28 Aug**

ANSWER

Student comms templates	**from late May**
Spec exceptions	**as needed**

TRAINING

EC platform (Salesforce)	**from Jul**
New regulations	**from Jul**
Compassionate communications	**from Aug**

TEST

Extenuating Circumstances platform UAT	**6–17 Jul**

Phase 3: Systems readiness

September – November

TRAINING

UPAS familiarisation	**from Aug**
UPAS aggregation	**from Oct**
BoE training	**from Oct**

Three EC Changes for 2026-27

Delayed Assessment Permits

Clearer, limited replacements for extensions

Cancel-and-Resit

Replaces untenable “Affected Performance” with sector-standard approach

Gradated Evidence

More humane paperwork requests when students are already struggling

Delayed Assessment Permits

These sit alongside ECs, not instead of them.

- Three permits per academic year, on top of the full EC system, instead of extensions
- Each gives a five-day extension on one piece of coursework
- (Not exams – but a discussion to happen this year)

How it works:

- Students notify via the online system before the deadline
- Extension applies automatically
- After three are used, appointment arranged with SSO

When to use them: Short-term disruption where students shouldn’t have evidence and don’t need wider support

DAPs and ECs

DAPs are for: A bad week, a minor illness, juggling life stresses – wider than the previous extensions rationale (*de jure*…).

ECs are for: Serious circumstances where students have evidence and may need support.

When UCL brought in in this system, three permits was more than enough for 76% of students. The rest had serious circumstances – and the full EC system was there for them.

Cancel-and-Resit

(Name still under discussion!)

Current system:

- Student sits an exam while unwell → claim “affected performance” before grades are released → approved at Stage 1 → wait months for a Board decision while being uncertain about the summer resits and your plans

How the new system works:

- Sit an exam while unwell/etc
- Claim with evidence before grades are released that you shouldn’t have sat the exam
- After stage 1, your attempt is immediately deleted
- You get a fresh attempt at the next opportunity, no penalty
- Decision is immediate after the evidence check

Gradated Evidence

Current approach:

- Every EC claim requires the same level of evidence, regardless of history
- Students with very serious and upsetting circumstances asked to get evidence

Proposal:

- First claim in a session: self-declaration for defined circumstances (bereavement, pregnancy loss, etc.)
- Automatic referral to wellbeing support
- Evidence requirements increase only with repeated claims



Changes to Policy and Regulations

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